

Haligric Research Integration Series

Methodism

A COMPLETE DEEP DIVE

The Wesleyan Way — Grace, Holiness, and Social Transformation

On the evening of May 24, 1738, at a meeting on Aldersgate Street in London, John Wesley felt his heart "strangely warmed" while someone was reading Luther's preface to the book of Romans. He wrote: "I felt I did trust in Christ, Christ alone for salvation." That moment changed the world.

Wesley called entire sanctification "the grand depositum" of the Methodist faith — the conviction that God can fill a human heart so completely with love that sin has nothing left to work on. Not theoretical perfection. The perfection of love.

Charles Wesley wrote 6,500 hymns. Through them, millions of people learned their theology not by reading but by singing. "O for a thousand tongues to sing / My great Redeemer's praise." The first tongue was enough to change England.

Contents

Introduction — What Is Methodism?	3
The Oxford Holy Club — The Method Before Methodism	4
John Wesley — Conversion and the Aldersgate Experience	5
Charles Wesley — The Hymn-Writer of the Reformation	6
Open-Air Preaching and the Methodist Societies	7
The Class Meeting — Accountable Discipleship	8
The General Rules — Do No Harm, Do Good, Attend to God	9
The Wesleyan Quadrilateral — Scripture, Tradition, Reason, Experience	10
Prevenient Grace — God Comes Before We Seek	11
Justification and the New Birth	12
Sanctification and Entire Sanctification	13
Christian Perfection — Perfect Love	14
The Means of Grace — Works of Piety and Mercy	15
Methodist Worship — The Sunday Service	16
A Methodist Service of Worship Step-by-Step	17
The Love Feast — An Apostolic Ordinance	19
The Sacraments in Methodist Theology	20
Methodist Hymnody — Singing the Faith	21
Social Holiness — The Public Dimension of Grace	22
Methodist Mission — Circuit Riders and Camp Meetings	23
Abolitionism and the AME Church	24
The United Methodist Church — History and Structure	25
The UMC Schism and the Global Methodist Church	26
Methodist Denominations Worldwide	27
The Haligricity Lens — Prevenient Grace and the Sacred Always-Already	28

Introduction — What Is Methodism?

Methodism is the branch of Protestant Christianity that emerged from the evangelical revival of 18th-century England, led by the Anglican priest John Wesley (1703-1791), his brother Charles Wesley (1707-1788), and the preacher George Whitefield (1714-1770). Named originally as an insult — critics mocked the Wesleys' "methodical" approach to the spiritual life — the Methodist movement became one of the most significant religious and social forces of the modern world, transforming the working-class communities of industrial England, spreading across the British Empire, and generating in America what became one of the largest Protestant churches in history.

With approximately 80 million members worldwide through its various denominational families — the United Methodist Church (the largest Methodist body), the African Methodist Episcopal Church, the African Methodist Episcopal Zion Church, the Church of the Nazarene, the Salvation Army, and dozens of others — Methodism has shaped global Christianity through its distinctive emphases: the universal scope of divine grace (available to all, not only the elect), the possibility of genuine personal transformation through sanctification, the priority of practical holiness over doctrinal precision, the centrality of community in the Christian life, and the insistence that personal salvation and social reform are inseparable.

What distinguishes Methodism from other Protestant traditions is not primarily its doctrine of justification (which it shares with Lutheranism) or its anti-Calvinism (which it shares with Arminianism more broadly) but its specific theological contribution: the doctrine of sanctification as a process that can culminate in entire sanctification or Christian perfection — the possibility of a life so thoroughly transformed by the Holy Spirit that love for God and neighbor becomes the dominant and governing orientation of the whole person. This claim — that the human being can be genuinely, substantially changed by grace, not merely justified while remaining sinful — is Wesley's most original and most contested theological contribution.

This document covers: the Oxford Holy Club and the origins of the Methodist method; John Wesley's biography including the Aldersgate experience; Charles Wesley and hymnody; the Methodist Societies, class meetings, and love feasts; the Wesleyan Quadrilateral; prevenient grace; justification and the New Birth; sanctification and entire sanctification; Christian perfection; the means of grace; Methodist worship including the Sunday Service and Love Feast; the sacraments; Methodist hymnody; social holiness; circuit riders, camp meetings, and the frontier mission; Methodism and abolitionism; the AME Church; the United Methodist Church; the 2022 schism and the Global Methodist Church; and worldwide Methodist denominations.

The Oxford Holy Club — The Method Before Methodism

Methodism did not begin with conversion or revival. It began with discipline. In 1729, Charles Wesley organized a small group of Oxford students committed to a rigorous, "methodical" approach to the Christian life — meeting regularly to read Scripture, fast twice a week (Wednesday and Friday), receive Holy Communion weekly, pray at set hours, study the Greek New Testament, and engage in acts of charity toward the poor, the sick, and the imprisoned. When John Wesley returned to Oxford from a brief ministry at his father's parish at Epworth, he joined this group and became its leader.

The Oxford Holy Club (also called the Bible-Moths, the Sacramentarians, and — most enduringly — the Methodists) was mocked by other Oxford students for its earnestness and its discipline. The nickname "Methodist" was intended to ridicule the group's systematic approach to piety; the Wesleys eventually embraced it. What the Holy Club was doing, without yet knowing it, was developing the community practices that would define the Methodist movement: small-group accountability, mutual confession of faults, regular sacramental practice, and direct service to the poor — all embedded in a structured weekly rhythm.

The Holy Club sent Wesley and Charles to Georgia in 1736 as missionaries to the colonists and Native Americans. The mission was largely a failure — Wesley was incompetent at the pastoral politics of a colonial settlement, fell into a disastrous personal entanglement with a parishioner, and was essentially forced to flee the colony. But the voyage to Georgia brought him into contact with a group of Moravian missionaries whose calm faith in the midst of a violent storm at sea impressed him deeply. The Moravians had something he did not: genuine assurance of salvation. He returned to England seeking what they had.

John Wesley — Conversion and the Aldersgate Experience

John Wesley was born in 1703 in Epworth, Lincolnshire, the fifteenth of nineteen children of Samuel Wesley (a Church of England rector) and Susanna Wesley — herself a remarkable theological thinker who conducted her own domestic religious instruction for her children and who is often recognized as one of the most important influences on her son's spiritual formation. As a child, John was rescued from a fire that destroyed the family rectory in 1709 — an experience that stayed with him as a sign of divine providence; he would later describe himself as "a brand plucked from the burning" (from Zechariah 3:2).

After the Georgia mission, Wesley returned to London spiritually unsettled. He had learned the forms of religion without the heart of it. He attended meetings of the Moravian society in London and consulted with their leader, Peter Boehler, who pressed him: "Preach faith until you have it; and then, because you have it, you will preach faith." On the evening of May 24, 1738, Wesley attended a meeting on Aldersgate Street, London, where someone was reading Luther's preface to the Epistle to the Romans. Wesley described what happened:

"About a quarter before nine, while he was describing the change which God works in the heart through faith in Christ, I felt my heart strangely warmed. I felt I did trust in Christ, Christ alone for salvation; and an assurance was given me that He had taken away my sins, even mine, and saved me from the law of sin and death."

The Aldersgate experience was not Wesley's initial conversion — he had been a believing, practicing Christian for decades. It was the gift of assurance: the experiential certainty that the forgiveness he had intellectually affirmed was genuinely his. This emphasis on the witness of the Spirit — the subjective, experiential assurance of salvation — became one of the most distinctive marks of Wesleyan theology, distinguishing it from both the Lutheran emphasis on the objective word of promise and the Calvinist emphasis on election as the ground of assurance.

Wesley lived until 1791, dying at the age of 87 after a ministry of extraordinary scope and energy. He preached approximately 40,000 sermons, traveled about 250,000 miles (primarily on horseback), and wrote and published prolifically on theology, medicine, natural philosophy, and practical ethics. He organized tens of thousands of converts into Methodist societies across England, Ireland, Scotland, and Wales, and supervised the beginning of American Methodism. He never intended to found a denomination; he died as an ordained Anglican priest, insisting that Methodism was a renewal movement within the Church of England, not a separate church. His death made the separation inevitable.

Charles Wesley — The Hymn-Writer of the Reformation

Charles Wesley (1707-1788) is one of the most significant figures in the history of Christian hymnody — the man who gave the Methodist movement its voice. He wrote approximately 6,500 hymns — a staggering output sustained over sixty years of active ministry — of which many have become classics of Protestant worship used by Christians of every tradition. He was also a gifted preacher and an important theological thinker, though his brother's organizational genius overshadowed him in institutional terms.

Charles Wesley's hymns are not merely devotional expressions — they are systematic theology in verse form. Wesley worked through the full range of Christian doctrine in his hymns: creation, the fall, justification, the New Birth, sanctification, entire sanctification, the sacraments, the last things. His hymns on Holy Communion — collected in *Hymns on the Lord's Supper* (1745), co-authored with John — are among the most theologically sophisticated eucharistic poetry in English. His Christmas hymn "Hark! the Herald Angels Sing" (originally "Hark, How All the Welkin Rings") encodes an entire Christology in three stanzas. His Easter hymn "Christ the Lord Is Risen Today" continues to be one of the most widely sung hymns in global Christianity.

The most important Charles Wesley hymn for understanding Methodist theology is "Love Divine, All Loves Excelling" — a meditation on entire sanctification cast in the form of a prayer: "Finish, then, thy new creation; / Pure and spotless let us be; / Let us see thy great salvation / Perfectly restored in thee... Changed from glory into glory, / Till in heaven we take our place, / Till we cast our crowns before thee, / Lost in wonder, love, and praise." The hymn describes the goal of the sanctified life: not merely forgiven but genuinely transformed — changed, from glory into glory, until the whole person is lost in the divine love.

Charles Wesley's other contribution was the method of singing itself. The early Methodist societies sang with an intensity and a collective energy that was new to English religious practice — congregational singing as active participation, as corporate testimony, as the whole community declaring its theology together at full voice. George Whitefield reportedly said that Charles Wesley's hymns had done more for the spread of Methodism than all John Wesley's sermons.

Open-Air Preaching and the Methodist Societies

The decisive turn in John Wesley's ministry came in April 1739, when George Whitefield — who had already been preaching to massive crowds of coal miners in the open fields outside Bristol — invited Wesley to continue the work. Wesley was initially reluctant; he was an Oxford-trained Anglican clergyman with a high view of ecclesiastical order, and open-air preaching outside the church walls seemed irregular and disrespectful of proper forms. But faced with Whitefield's insistence and the obvious spiritual need of the crowds Whitefield was drawing, Wesley preached to three thousand people in the field near Bristol.

"I submitted to be more vile," Wesley wrote in his journal, "and proclaimed in the highways the glad tidings of salvation." The decision to preach wherever people would hear — in fields, in mine shafts, on street corners, at market squares — was the organizational key that unlocked the Methodist movement. The established Church of England served the respectable, the propertied, the settled. The industrial poor of England's growing cities, the miners and factory workers and servants, had no church that reached them. Wesley went to them.

The converts made through open-air preaching were organized into Methodist Societies — not churches, but intentional communities within (in Wesley's intention) the Church of England structure. Societies were organized in cities and towns throughout England, each meeting weekly for prayer, singing, Scripture reading, preaching, and mutual accountability. Wesley traveled continuously, visiting societies, appointing and supervising lay preachers, and maintaining the organizational coherence of a movement that had no formal denominational structure.

The appointment of lay preachers — men and women without formal theological education or Anglican ordination — was one of Wesley's most radical innovations. The Methodist lay preacher was assessed not by credentials but by gifts and graces: did their preaching bear fruit? Were there conversions? Did the people they served grow in holiness? This pragmatic, fruit-oriented criterion for ministry authorization anticipated the revivalist tradition that would shape American Protestantism for the next two centuries.

The Class Meeting — Accountable Discipleship

The class meeting was the institutional genius of early Methodism — the specific organizational innovation that distinguished Methodist revival from other evangelical movements and gave the Methodist conversion a community context in which it could be sustained and deepened. Without the class meeting, Methodist converts would have been swept up in revival feeling and then returned, without support or accountability, to the social environments that had formed them in the first place. The class meeting provided the ongoing community of transformation.

The class meeting emerged accidentally. Wesley had divided Bristol Methodist Society members into groups of twelve to facilitate the collection of weekly dues from those who couldn't afford to pay a penny a week for the construction of the New Room (the Bristol preaching house). The class leaders who visited members to collect dues quickly discovered that their visits were revealing a more urgent need: people who had been converted needed regular spiritual care. Wesley reorganized the class structure around this pastoral reality: classes would meet weekly, not for financial administration, but for mutual spiritual oversight.

The class meeting followed a simple structure. The class leader — typically a layperson — opened with a hymn and prayer, then shared something of their own spiritual experience during the week: how they had grown, where they had struggled, what grace they had received. Each member of the class then did the same. The format was direct: "How is it with your soul this week?" was Wesley's own formulation. Members were expected to be honest — to share not only victories but failures, not only spiritual progress but specific sins and temptations. The class leader offered counsel, prayer, and sometimes correction.

This format of honest mutual confession and accountability within a small community produced what Wesley called "watching over one another in love" — a communal practice of holiness in which the progress or struggle of one member became the concern of all. The class meeting was not therapy (though it had therapeutic effects), not a support group (though it provided support), and not a Bible study (though Scripture was central). It was a community of practice oriented toward the specific goal of holiness of heart and life.

Wesley issued quarterly membership tickets to class meeting participants — a simple token confirming that the person was in good standing as a Methodist, having attended their class and demonstrated continued commitment to the Methodist way. No ticket, no admission to the Love Feast or to specific society meetings. This disciplinary structure maintained a level of communal seriousness about the pursuit of holiness that distinguished Methodism from revivalist movements that generated large conversions without sustained formation.

The General Rules — Do No Harm, Do Good, Attend to God

Wesley formulated the General Rules of the United Societies in 1743 as the basic conditions of membership in a Methodist Society. They remain officially in force in the United Methodist Church today. They are strikingly simple and practically oriented — more ethical than doctrinal, more behavioral than creedal. Wesley was explicit about this: he did not impose a doctrinal test for membership. The single requirement was "a desire to flee from the wrath to come, to be saved from their sins" — a desire demonstrated by living according to three rules.

FIRST: DO NO HARM — avoiding evil of every kind, specifically including: taking the name of God in vain; profaning the Lord's Day; drunkenness; fighting, quarreling, and brawling; buying or selling goods that have not paid duty; giving or taking money on usury (interest for profit); uncharitable conversation; and "doing to others as we would not they should do unto us." Wesley's original list reflects the specific social vices of 18th-century England; the principle is universal.

SECOND: DO GOOD — specifically, doing good of every possible sort to the bodies and souls of people, including: giving food to the hungry, clothing to the naked, visiting the sick and imprisoned; "doing good, especially to them that are of the household of faith"; attempting to instruct, reprove, and exhort all we have any interaction with; and working toward the improvement of the community in its political, social, and economic dimensions. Wesley understood salvation as having a social dimension that was inseparable from its personal dimension.

THIRD: ATTEND TO THE ORDINANCES OF GOD — specifically: public worship, the ministry of the Word (preaching), the Lord's Supper (Holy Communion), family and private prayer, searching the Scriptures, and fasting or abstinence. These are what Wesley called the "means of grace" — the specific channels through which God's transforming grace operates in the life of the believer.

The General Rules are a masterpiece of practical ethics: comprehensive without being legalistic, demanding without being punitive, and grounded in the single transforming purpose of holiness. They anticipated the later Methodist emphasis on social holiness by grounding the individual's ethical life in a communal framework of mutual accountability. The person who keeps these three rules is not merely a good individual — they are a member of a community that is actively working to reform the world.

The Wesleyan Quadrilateral — Scripture, Tradition, Reason, Experience

The Wesleyan Quadrilateral is the theological method associated with Wesley and formalized by the 20th-century Methodist theologian Albert Outler — the four sources of theological authority that Wesley employed in his theological reflection: Scripture, Tradition, Reason, and Experience. The Quadrilateral does not treat these four sources as equal — Scripture holds primary authority; the other three serve as aids to the interpretation of Scripture.

SCRIPTURE: Wesley called himself "a man of one book" — *homo unius libri* — meaning that Scripture was his primary and supreme authority. Everything else in theology was measured against Scripture. But Wesley's reading of Scripture was not naive literalism; it was hermeneutically sophisticated, attending to the whole canon, the consensus of interpretation across traditions, and the internal logic of the biblical text. His fifty-three Standard Sermons and his Notes on the New Testament remain the primary doctrinal standards of Wesleyan theology — not a systematic theology but an extensive engagement with the biblical text.

TRADITION: Wesley believed that the teaching of the early church, the Church Fathers, and the broader Christian tradition provided important guidance for the interpretation of Scripture. He read patristics extensively — more extensively than most Protestant theologians of his era — and drew on the Eastern Fathers (especially Clement of Alexandria, Origen, and Macarius of Egypt) in ways that gave his theology a distinctive flavor, particularly his doctrine of sanctification.

REASON: Wesley was an educated 18th-century intellectual who affirmed the importance of rational argument in theology. He did not divorce faith from reason; he believed that genuine Christian doctrine must be capable of rational defense. This rationalist dimension gave Methodism an intellectual seriousness that coexisted with its emotional revivalism — Wesley was simultaneously a preacher of the heartwarming Gospel and a systematic thinker who engaged in careful doctrinal argument.

EXPERIENCE: The most distinctive and most controversial element of the Wesleyan Quadrilateral. Wesley believed that the experienced reality of grace in the life of the believer — the subjective sense of forgiveness, the felt assurance of God's love, the experienced transformation of character — provided important evidence for theological claims. The doctrine of prevenient grace, for example, was supported not only by Scripture and tradition but by the universal human experience of some sense of moral awareness and divine call, even among those who had never heard the Gospel. The doctrine of entire sanctification was supported not only by Wesley's biblical exegesis but by the reported experiences of those who testified to having received it.

Prevenient Grace — God Comes Before We Seek

Prevenient grace (from the Latin *praeveniens* — going before) is the theological concept most distinctive to Wesleyan theology and the key to understanding how Methodism navigates the relationship between divine sovereignty and human freedom. The claim: God's grace precedes and prepares every human being for salvation — not only those who will ultimately be saved, but all human beings without exception. Before anyone seeks God, God has already been seeking them.

The theological problem prevenient grace solves: Reformed theology (Calvinism) affirms divine sovereignty by teaching that God elects specific individuals for salvation and passes others by — the human being cannot respond to God without first being given the grace to respond, and that grace is given only to the elect. Catholic and Eastern Orthodox theology affirms human freedom by teaching that grace cooperates with the human will. Wesley wants to affirm both: genuine divine initiative (grace truly enables the human response) and genuine human freedom (the human being truly chooses).

The Wesleyan solution: God extends prevenient grace to all human beings — a grace that restores to fallen humanity sufficient freedom to respond to the Gospel. Original sin has corrupted human nature and disabled genuine free choice in matters of salvation; prevenient grace does not eliminate sin but temporarily restores the capacity to respond. This is why Wesley rejected total inability (the Calvinist claim that the fallen human will is entirely incapable of responding to God) without affirming Pelagianism (the claim that human beings can choose God from their own natural resources). The ability to respond is itself a gift of grace — universal grace, given to all, not only to the elect.

Prevenient grace is the theological foundation of Wesley's conviction that God genuinely desires the salvation of all people and that the Gospel may be offered to all people without distinction. Unlike Calvinist preaching, which must (on its own logic) acknowledge that some of the hearers may not be among the elect, Wesleyan preaching can say to every individual: "Christ died for you. God loves you. You can be saved." The universal scope of prevenient grace grounds the universal scope of evangelistic invitation.

Justification and the New Birth

Wesley's doctrine of justification is essentially Lutheran in its structure: sinners are justified by grace through faith — not by works, not by merit, not by sacramental participation, but by trusting in Christ's atoning work on their behalf. Wesley was explicit about his agreement with the Reformers on this point. His 1738 Aldersgate experience was a direct encounter with the doctrine of justification as Luther understood it — the assurance of forgiveness received by faith, not achieved by effort.

The distinction Wesley makes that is not in Luther is between justification and the New Birth. Justification, for Wesley, is what God does for us — the pardoning of sins, the restoration of right standing before God. The New Birth (regeneration) is what God does in us — the beginning of the actual transformation of the human person by the Holy Spirit. Both happen simultaneously at the moment of initial faith, but they are conceptually distinct and have different trajectories: justification is complete at the moment of conversion; the New Birth begins a process of growth that, in Wesley's theology, can continue to entire sanctification.

The assurance of salvation — the witness of the Spirit — is central to Wesley's understanding of the New Birth. He believed that genuine conversion typically (though not always) produces a subjective sense of God's love and forgiveness — an interior witness that confirms the objective promise of the Gospel. This assurance is not the ground of salvation (which is Christ's atoning work received by faith) but a fruit of genuine faith. The absence of assurance does not necessarily indicate the absence of salvation, but the presence of assurance is one of the marks of genuine conversion.

Sanctification and Entire Sanctification

Sanctification is the aspect of Wesleyan theology that is most distinctive and most persistently controversial. Where the Lutheran tradition distinguishes sharply between justification (complete) and sanctification (always incomplete in this life — *simul iustus et peccator*, simultaneously justified and sinner), Wesley teaches that sanctification is a real and progressing transformation of the human person that can, in this life, reach a state of entire sanctification or Christian perfection.

The Wesleyan understanding of sanctification is not a single dramatic event (though Wesley and those who followed him in the Holiness movement often spoke of a "second blessing" — a definable moment of entire sanctification). It is primarily a process — the progressive transformation of the human character by the Holy Spirit, growing in love for God and neighbor, declining in the power of sin's control, and being increasingly conformed to the image of Christ. This process involves the cooperation of the human will with divine grace — another point of distinction from Calvinist theology, in which sanctification is entirely a work of the Spirit without human contribution.

Entire sanctification is Wesley's term for the goal of the sanctification process — a state in which the believer's heart is so filled with love for God and neighbor that sin has no longer any hold on them. Wesley was careful to define what he meant and did not mean. Entire sanctification does not mean: freedom from ignorance, mistakes, or human imperfection; freedom from the susceptibility to temptation; or the inability to fall from grace subsequently. It does mean: freedom from voluntary sin; purification of the heart's dominant orientation; and the fullness of the first and second commandments (love God with all your heart, soul, mind, and strength; love your neighbor as yourself) as the governing reality of the person's inner life.

Wesley taught entire sanctification as both possible and expected — something that should be sought earnestly and that God desires to give. His encouragement to seek entire sanctification was one of the most distinctive and controversial elements of early Methodism. Critics argued (and continue to argue) that the doctrine encourages spiritual pride and delusion. Wesley's defenders argue that the doctrine is simply the logical implication of his theology of grace: if God can save a sinner, God can also complete the work of salvation — not in the next life only, but in this one.

Christian Perfection — Perfect Love

Wesley's term "Christian perfection" has caused more misunderstanding than perhaps any other concept in his theology — primarily because of the word "perfection," which in common usage implies the absence of all flaws and failures. Wesley means something different and more precise. Christian perfection is perfect love — the state of a heart so thoroughly oriented toward love for God and neighbor that this love is the governing and dominant reality of the person's interior life.

"By perfection I mean the humble, gentle, patient love of God, and our neighbor, ruling our tempers, words, and actions." Wesley was emphatic that he did not mean sinless perfection in the absolute sense: the entirely sanctified person can still make mistakes, have wrong judgments, and fail in various ways. What they do not do is voluntarily, willfully transgress a known law of God — because the love of God and neighbor that governs their heart makes such transgression contrary to their deepest desire.

Wesley also insisted that Christian perfection does not preclude further growth — it is not a static achievement but a dynamic state that can deepen indefinitely. The term he preferred, alongside "entire sanctification," was "perfect love" — expressing the relational character of the state. Perfect love is not a theological proposition or a moral achievement; it is a relationship with God in which love is the medium, the content, and the goal.

The Holiness movement of the 19th century — spawned largely by the Tuesday Meetings led by Phoebe Palmer (1807-1874) in New York City — took Wesley's doctrine of entire sanctification and developed it into a more defined crisis experience, accessible through specific methods (full consecration, claiming the promise by faith, testifying to the experience). Palmer's "altar theology" simplified Wesley's careful gradualism into a more immediately accessible form, and the Holiness movement that resulted eventually spawned the Pentecostal movement of the early 20th century.

The Means of Grace — Works of Piety and Mercy

Wesley's theology of the means of grace is one of his most practically significant contributions — a comprehensive account of the specific practices through which God's transforming grace operates in human life. Wesley defined means of grace as "outward signs, words, or actions ordained of God, and appointed for this end, to be the ordinary channels whereby he might convey to men, preventing, justifying, or sanctifying grace."

Wesley divided the means of grace into two categories. The Works of Piety are the specifically religious practices that maintain and deepen the relationship with God: public worship, the ministry of the Word (preaching), the Lord's Supper, private prayer, family prayer, searching the Scriptures, fasting, and the class meeting. The Works of Mercy are the practices of service and justice that express love for the neighbor: feeding the hungry, clothing the naked, visiting the sick and imprisoned, instructing the ignorant, and working for the reform of social conditions that produce suffering.

The integration of works of piety and works of mercy in a single theological category — both as means of grace — is one of the most theologically sophisticated aspects of Wesleyan thought. It is not that religious practice earns grace, nor that social service is the practical expression of grace already received. Rather, both are channels through which grace operates in both directions: grace produces the desire to serve, and the act of service opens the person further to grace. In Wesley's theology, the spiritual and the social are not separate spheres; they are two modes of the same transforming divine movement in human life.

Wesley was also attentive to what he called "prudential means of grace" — practices not explicitly commanded in Scripture but found by experience to be channels of divine grace. The class meeting itself was the primary prudential means; Wesley developed it empirically, discovering its effect and affirming it on the basis of results rather than biblical command. This pragmatic, experience-based approach to spiritual practice anticipated the later Methodist tradition of adapting methods to context while maintaining the theological goal of holiness.

Methodist Worship — The Sunday Service

Methodist worship originated with Wesley's 1784 abridgment of the Anglican Book of Common Prayer, titled *The Sunday Service of the Methodists* — a streamlined version of the Anglican liturgy adapted for the Methodist societies in America, which had separated from the Church of England following the American Revolution. Wesley removed what he considered Anglican elements that were culturally specific to England (references to the monarch, the Articles of Religion minus those directly relevant to Christian doctrine) and preserved the core structure of Anglican worship: prayers, Scripture reading, psalm singing, preaching, and the sacraments.

Over time, the formal liturgy of early Methodism gave way to a more flexible, extemporaneous style — particularly in the American context, where the frontier camp meeting and circuit rider tradition shaped a more informal, participation-centered worship practice. By the 20th century, Methodist worship in America ranged from nearly Anglican in its liturgical formality to nearly charismatic in its informality, with the majority of congregations somewhere in between.

The contemporary United Methodist Church uses the *United Methodist Hymnal* (1989) and the *United Methodist Book of Worship* (1992), both of which provide a range of resources including both formal liturgical orders and more flexible formats. The standard Sunday service follows a fourfold pattern common to many mainstream Protestant churches: Gathering, Word, Response, Sending Forth — a pattern that moves from the community's gathering in praise, through the proclamation of Scripture, to a response of faith and service, and finally to the commissioning of the community for mission in the world.

A Methodist Service of Worship Step-by-Step

The following order represents a typical contemporary United Methodist Sunday service following the fourfold pattern:

Gathering

PRELUDE: Music preparing the congregation for worship.

GATHERING HYMN: A congregational hymn (often a Charles Wesley hymn or a traditional Methodist favorite) as the community assembles. Congregational singing has always been central to Methodist worship.

GREETING AND CALL TO WORSHIP: The pastor greets the congregation and reads a call to worship from Scripture, inviting the community to focus on God.

OPENING PRAYER: A brief prayer of praise and acknowledgment of God's presence.

CONFESSION AND PARDON: The congregation confesses sin together, followed by the pastor's declaration of pardon in Christ's name.

Word

FIRST LESSON: An Old Testament or Epistle reading.

PSALM: Read responsively, sung, or chanted.

GOSPEL LESSON: The reading of the Gospel for the day, the congregation standing.

SERMON: The central act of Methodist preaching — typically 20-30 minutes, expository or topical, oriented toward both the intellectual understanding of Scripture and the experiential appropriation of its grace. Methodist preaching at its best moves from the biblical text through doctrinal clarification to personal and social application — with the goal not merely of informing but of transforming. The altar call (an invitation for people to come forward in response to the sermon for prayer, commitment, or entire sanctification) remains a distinctive element in many Methodist services.

THE APOSTLES' CREED: Confessed together, expressing the shared faith of the Church across centuries.

Response

HYMN OF RESPONSE: A hymn responding to the proclaimed Word.

PRAYERS OF THE PEOPLE: Intercessions offered for the Church, the world, those in need, and the local community.

OFFERING: The congregation's financial offering, received as an act of worship.

LORD'S TABLE (HOLY COMMUNION): Celebrated weekly in some Methodist congregations, monthly or quarterly in others. Wesley urged weekly Communion as a means of grace; contemporary Methodism has moved toward more frequent celebration. The Great Thanksgiving — the central eucharistic prayer — follows the form of the ancient Western liturgy: Sursum Corda (Lift up your hearts), Preface, Sanctus, institution narrative, memorial acclamation, epiclesis, Lord's Prayer, and distribution. The UMC affirms "the real presence of Christ" in the Supper while affirming that "how this happens" is "a holy mystery" — a characteristically Methodist refusal to specify the mechanism.

Sending Forth

SENDING HYMN: A final congregational hymn for the community going into mission.

BENEDICTION: The pastor blesses the congregation.

POSTLUDE: Music as the congregation departs.

The Love Feast — An Apostolic Ordinance

The Love Feast (Agape Feast) is one of the most distinctive and most theologically significant Methodist practices — a form of worship that combines the sharing of simple food (usually bread and water) with the sharing of spiritual testimonies, and that Wesley understood as a restoration of an apostolic practice found in the early Church. Wesley encountered the Love Feast among the Moravians in Georgia, was impressed by its spiritual power, and introduced it into the Methodist societies.

The Love Feast is not the Eucharist — it uses different elements (bread and water rather than bread and wine), is not restricted to baptized communicants, and does not invoke the same sacramental theology as Holy Communion. It is a communal meal of fellowship in which the primary "substance" is not the food but the testimonies: each participant shares what God has been doing in their life — experiences of conversion, growth, struggle, grace, answered prayer. The sharing of testimony is the heart of the Love Feast, with the simple food serving as the material expression of the community's shared life.

Wesley described the Love Feast as an experience of extraordinary power: "The love feast which followed was such as I had not seen for many years. The spirit of love was poured out upon all present, and they all showed their sense of God's goodness by speaking what they had felt." The Love Feast became less common as Methodism institutionalized, but it has been revived in recent years as part of the contemporary interest in Wesleyan spiritual practices. It represents one of the clearest expressions of the Methodist conviction that authentic Christian community requires honest mutual disclosure — the willingness to share not only praise and gratitude but struggle and failure within a community that receives both with grace.

The Sacraments in Methodist Theology

Methodist theology recognizes two sacraments: Baptism and Holy Communion. This follows Wesley's reduction of the Anglican seven sacraments (which were never seven in the Anglican tradition either — the Thirty-Nine Articles distinguished the two dominical sacraments from the five "commonly called sacraments"). Wesley retained and amplified the Anglican emphasis on sacramental practice while articulating the theology of the sacraments in distinctively Wesleyan terms.

BAPTISM: Wesley practiced infant baptism, understanding it as the initiating sacrament of incorporation into the covenant community and a means of prevenient grace. However, the Methodist tradition has been more flexible on this question than either the Catholic/Orthodox tradition (which requires infant baptism) or the Baptist tradition (which rejects it). The United Methodist Church practices both infant baptism (understood as the church's declaration of God's prevenient grace and the covenant community's commitment to nurture the child in the faith) and believer's baptism (for adults who were not baptized as infants).

THE LORD'S SUPPER: Wesley not only retained the practice of Holy Communion from his Anglican heritage — he actually urged its more frequent practice. In his sermon "The Duty of Constant Communion" (1787), Wesley argued that Christians should receive Holy Communion as often as possible — weekly if available — because it is one of the primary means of grace, a channel through which God conveys both justifying and sanctifying grace. This "constant communion" theology was significantly more sacramentally serious than most of the Protestant revivalism with which Methodism was contemporary.

The Methodist understanding of Christ's presence in the Lord's Supper is expressed in the characteristic Wesleyan phrase "a holy mystery." Methodism rejects transubstantiation (the Catholic claim that the substance of bread and wine is transformed) and explicit memorialism (the Zwinglian claim that the Lord's Supper is purely symbolic). It affirms that Christ is truly present in the Supper — but how this is so, what the mechanism of presence is, what specifically happens to the bread and wine — these questions are left open, as they should be in the presence of a divine mystery.

Methodist Hymnody — Singing the Faith

Charles Wesley's 6,500 hymns represent the largest body of sacred song by a single author in Christian history, and they remain the theological heartbeat of the Methodist tradition. Beyond Charles Wesley, the Methodist movement produced a broader hymnological tradition that has shaped Protestant worship globally. Fanny Crosby (1820-1915) — a Methodist and the most prolific female hymn-writer in history — wrote approximately 8,000 hymns, including "Blessed Assurance," "To God Be the Glory," and "Pass Me Not, O Gentle Savior." The gospel song tradition that emerged from the Holiness and camp meeting movements (hymns like "What a Friend We Have in Jesus," "In the Garden," "It Is Well with My Soul") owes its primary debt to the Methodist revivalist tradition.

Wesley's "Directions for Singing" — included in the Methodist hymnbooks — set the standard for congregational singing: sing all the verses (don't skip any); sing together (not some parts ahead of others); sing modestly (not louder than others, not so soft as to be unhelpful); sing in time (with the congregation); above all, "see that your heart is not carried away with the sound, but offered to God continually." The goal of singing is not musical performance or emotional experience; it is the offering of the whole person to God through the medium of music and theology woven together.

Key Charles Wesley hymns and their theological freight: "O for a Thousand Tongues to Sing" (1739) — a hymn of evangelistic joy, celebrating the power of Jesus's name. Written on the first anniversary of his conversion, it encapsulates the Methodist experience of joyful transformation. "Love Divine, All Loves Excelling" — the theology of entire sanctification in verse. "Christ the Lord Is Risen Today" — the theology of resurrection; the Easter proclamation in its most jubilant form. "Hark! The Herald Angels Sing" — a sophisticated Christology: "Veiled in flesh the Godhead see / Hail the incarnate Deity / Pleased as man with men to dwell / Jesus, our Emmanuel." "Jesus, Lover of My Soul" — the theology of trust in divine mercy; one of the most widely loved Christian hymns of all time.

Social Holiness — The Public Dimension of Grace

The phrase "social holiness" is one of the most important in Methodist history — coined by Wesley himself in his preface to the 1739 Methodist Hymns: "The gospel of Christ knows of no holiness but social holiness." By this Wesley did not mean what contemporary "social justice" language typically means — he was not primarily talking about political reform. He was talking about the inescapably communal nature of the Christian life: holiness cannot be pursued in isolation; it requires and is shaped by community.

But the social dimension of Methodist holiness quickly took on the political and economic implications that are now associated with the phrase. Wesley himself was an outspoken opponent of slavery (his last letter, written days before his death in 1791, was to William Wilberforce encouraging his campaign for abolition), a critic of economic exploitation, an advocate for education for the poor, and the founder of the first free medical clinic in Bristol. His understanding of entire sanctification as perfect love for neighbor meant that love expressed in social action was not optional add-on to the spiritual life but intrinsic to it.

The Methodist tradition has consistently generated social reform movements: Wilberforce's campaign for the abolition of slavery in Britain was significantly shaped by his Methodist faith (though Wilberforce was technically an evangelical Anglican, the social reform networks he moved in were heavily Methodist). The Temperance movement — the campaign against alcohol that produced Prohibition in the United States — was largely a Methodist initiative, driven by the conviction that alcohol was destroying the lives of the working poor. The early trade union movement in Britain had deep roots in Methodist working-class communities. The settlement house movement (epitomized by Jane Addams's Hull House in Chicago) drew heavily on Methodist social theology.

Methodist Mission — Circuit Riders and Camp Meetings

Methodism spread across America through two institutional innovations that were among the most significant in American religious history: the circuit rider and the camp meeting.

THE CIRCUIT RIDER: The itinerant Methodist preacher who traveled a regular circuit of communities — often covering hundreds of miles by horseback, preaching in homes, barns, courthouses, and open fields — was the primary agent of Methodist expansion on the American frontier. Francis Asbury (1745-1816), Wesley's appointed superintendent for American Methodism, is the defining figure: he traveled approximately 270,000 miles over 45 years, preaching more than 16,000 sermons and ordaining more than 4,000 preachers. The circuit rider brought the Gospel to communities that had no settled clergy, organized converts into Methodist societies and class meetings, and maintained the organizational coherence of the movement over vast distances. By 1820, the Methodist Episcopal Church was the largest Protestant denomination in the United States.

THE CAMP MEETING: The outdoor religious gathering — typically lasting several days, with crowds camping in tents or wagons around a central preaching stand — was an American invention that the Methodist movement made its own. The Cane Ridge Revival of 1801 in Kentucky (though technically Presbyterian in origin) ignited the Second Great Awakening; the camp meeting became the primary format through which that awakening spread. Methodist camp meetings were described by participants as overwhelming experiences of divine power: masses of people weeping, crying out, falling to the ground ("the jerks"), and declaring conversion or entire sanctification. Asbury called them "our harvest seasons." Henry Boehm reported 1,100 conversions and 600 entire sanctifications at a single camp meeting in Delaware in 1805.

The camp meeting tradition — with its altar calls, its testimony services, its emotional intensity, and its expectation of immediate divine action in response to earnest seeking — became the model for American revivalism more broadly. Its influence can be traced through the revivals of Charles Finney, Dwight L. Moody, and Billy Sunday; through Pentecostalism (which emerged partly from the Holiness camp meeting tradition); and ultimately through the structure of contemporary evangelical worship services.

Abolitionism and the AME Church

The relationship between Methodism and slavery in America is one of the most complex and most painful chapters in American religious history. Wesley himself was unequivocal: his 1774 pamphlet *Thoughts upon Slavery* called slavery "the sum of all villainies" and urged immediate abolition. Early American Methodism was explicitly anti-slavery: the Christmas Conference of 1784 (which organized the Methodist Episcopal Church in America) passed rules requiring Methodist preachers to free their slaves within a year. Within a few years, these rules were suspended under pressure from slaveholding Methodist members — a capitulation that would haunt the tradition for decades.

The African Methodist Episcopal (AME) Church was founded in 1816 by Richard Allen (1760-1831) in direct response to racial discrimination within the predominantly white Methodist Episcopal Church. Allen, a freed slave who had experienced conversion through Methodist preaching, had become a licensed Methodist preacher and helped found St. George's Methodist Episcopal Church in Philadelphia. When white ushers pulled Allen and other Black members from their knees during prayer and told them to sit in the gallery reserved for Blacks, Allen led them out of the church. He founded Bethel African Methodist Church in 1793, and in 1816 joined with other Black Methodist congregations to form the AME Church as an independent denomination.

The AME Church became one of the most significant institutions of African American community life — a church that combined Methodist theology and practice with the specific experience and cultural expression of the African American people. Frederick Douglass, Harriet Tubman, and many other figures of the abolitionist movement were either AME members or deeply connected to the AME network. The AME Church used its institutional structure to support the Underground Railroad, educate freed slaves, and advocate for civil rights.

The slavery question eventually split the Methodist Episcopal Church. In 1844, after a bitter debate over whether a bishop who owned slaves could continue to serve, the church divided into the Methodist Episcopal Church (North) and the Methodist Episcopal Church, South — a division that lasted until 1939, when the two branches reunited (along with the Methodist Protestant Church) to form The Methodist Church. This reunited church merged with the Evangelical United Brethren Church in 1968 to form the United Methodist Church.

The United Methodist Church — History and Structure

The United Methodist Church (UMC), formed in 1968 through the merger of The Methodist Church and the Evangelical United Brethren Church, is the second-largest Protestant denomination in the United States (after the Southern Baptist Convention) and one of the largest Methodist bodies in the world, with approximately 9-10 million members in the US and an additional 5 million members globally (primarily in Africa). Its headquarters are in Nashville, Tennessee.

The UMC is organized connectionally — the defining principle of Methodist polity. Unlike the congregational autonomy of Baptist churches or the Presbyterian hierarchy of the Reformed tradition, the Methodist connectional system links all congregations in a network of mutual accountability and shared mission. Local churches are connected through district superintendents to annual conferences (regional bodies that include all clergy and lay delegates from a geographic area), which are in turn connected through jurisdictional conferences to the General Conference (the supreme legislative body, meeting every four years, which makes binding decisions for the entire denomination).

The United Methodist Church ordains women to all orders of ministry (the first ordination of women as full members of an annual conference occurred in 1956) and is organizationally committed to racial and ethnic diversity. It maintains significant institutional presence through its hospitals, universities, and social service agencies. Methodist-related universities include Duke University, Emory University, Northwestern University, Southern Methodist University, and Boston University, among many others.

The UMC Schism and the Global Methodist Church

The United Methodist Church underwent a major schism in 2022-2023 over the question of human sexuality — specifically, the denomination's prohibition on the ordination of "self-avowed practicing homosexuals" as clergy and on the performance of same-sex marriages by United Methodist clergy. This prohibition, in force since 1972 when the phrase "incompatible with Christian teaching" was first added to the Book of Discipline, had been debated, violated, litigated, and re-affirmed through multiple General Conferences without resolution.

The Global Methodist Church (GMC) was formed on May 1, 2022, as a theologically conservative alternative — a denomination committed to traditional Wesleyan theology and the historic Methodist understanding of Scripture's authority on questions of human sexuality. By the end of 2023, approximately 7,700 United Methodist congregations (roughly one quarter of US UMC congregations) had disaffiliated from the UMC, the majority joining the GMC. The disaffiliation process was facilitated by a provision in the UMC Book of Discipline (Paragraph 2553) that allowed congregations to leave with their property through December 31, 2023.

The 2024 UMC General Conference, meeting in Charlotte, North Carolina, removed the "incompatible with Christian teaching" language from the Book of Discipline and changed the UMC's policies to permit the ordination of LGBTQ+ clergy and the performance of same-sex marriages. The remaining UMC, substantially reduced in the US but still the largest Methodist body globally (with strong growth in Africa), moved forward in a more progressive theological direction. The African UMC conferences, which had strongly opposed the policy changes, were in the process of determining their relationship to the denomination as of 2025-2026.

Methodist Denominations Worldwide

The Methodist family of churches is extraordinarily diverse — encompassing liturgical and charismatic, social justice-oriented and holiness-focused, mainline and conservative expressions of the Wesleyan inheritance.

THE AFRICAN METHODIST EPISCOPAL CHURCH (AME): Founded 1816. Approximately 2.5 million members. Primarily African American; historically and currently one of the most important Black institutions in American life. Played a central role in the civil rights movement. The massacre at Mother Emanuel AME Church in Charleston, South Carolina (2015) — when a white supremacist killed nine people during a Bible study — is one of the most painful recent events in American religious history.

THE AFRICAN METHODIST EPISCOPAL ZION CHURCH (AME Zion): Founded 1821. Approximately 1.4 million members. Called "The Freedom Church" for its historic role in the abolition movement. Frederick Douglass, Sojourner Truth, and Harriet Tubman were all connected to AME Zion congregations.

THE CHURCH OF THE NAZARENE: A Holiness denomination that traces its roots to the 19th-century Holiness movement and its doctrine of entire sanctification. With approximately 2.5 million members worldwide and significant presence in the developing world, the Church of the Nazarene is one of the most globally distributed Holiness-Wesleyan bodies.

THE SALVATION ARMY: Founded in 1865 by William and Catherine Booth in London. Not a church in the conventional sense but a paramilitary-structured Christian charitable organization with approximately 1.7 million members and an enormous global social service presence. The Salvation Army's theology is explicitly Wesleyan-Holiness; its distinctive uniforms, brass bands, and street ministry descend directly from the Methodist revivalist tradition.

THE GLOBAL METHODIST CHURCH: Founded 2022. A theologically conservative denomination formed primarily by congregations that disaffiliated from the United Methodist Church. Committed to Wesleyan theology, biblical authority, and traditional Methodist practice. Still developing its polity and institutional structures as of 2026.

METHODIST CHURCH OF GREAT BRITAIN: The primary Methodist body in England, formed in 1932 through the merger of three earlier Methodist bodies. Approximately 165,000 members — a significant decline from the peak of British Methodism in the early 20th century. Ordains women and has been engaged in conversations with the Church of England about potential reunion for decades.

The Haligricity Lens — Prevenient Grace and the Sacred Always-Already

Methodism offers the Haligric practitioner the most pastorally accessible and the most universally applicable of all the Protestant traditions' theological gifts: prevenient grace — the recognition that God is already present, already working, already seeking the human person before the person has any conscious awareness of seeking God. No one arrives at the sacred from a standing start. The grace always precedes the seeking.

Prevenient Grace — The Divine Already-There

The Wesleyan doctrine of prevenient grace is the Protestant tradition's most direct articulation of what every tradition in the library knows about the priority of the sacred over human seeking. The Buddhist teaching that Buddha-nature is already present in every sentient being — that enlightenment is not something to be achieved but recognized; the Vedantic teaching that the Atman is already Brahman and that the spiritual path is the removal of the obscuration that hides this truth; the Sufi teaching that God is closer to the human being than the jugular vein; the African traditional recognition that the divine is already animating all life and that the sacred practitioner is learning to notice what is always already there — all of these are expressions of the same recognition that Wesley named prevenient grace. You do not bring God into your life. You discover that God was already there.

Perfect Love — The Goal of Sacred Practice

Wesley's concept of perfect love — a heart so thoroughly oriented toward love for God and neighbor that this love is the governing reality of the interior life — is the Methodist tradition's articulation of what every contemplative tradition in the library names as the goal of sacred practice. The Sufi fana (dissolution of the self in divine love); the Buddhist metta (boundless loving-kindness that extends to all beings without exception); the Christian agape (unconditional love that mirrors divine love for humanity); the African Ubuntu (the understanding that "I am because we are" — that the fullness of the self is realized only in community) — all of these point toward the same experiential territory that Wesley named perfect love. It is not theoretical perfection but a specific quality of heart in which love is no longer merely a feeling or an effort but the fundamental orientation of the person.

Social Holiness — The Inseparability of Inner and Outer

Wesley's insistence that "there is no holiness but social holiness" is the Methodist tradition's clearest expression of what the Haligric tradition holds about the relationship between inner transformation and outer engagement. The person who seeks holiness in private, without the community of accountability that the class meeting provides, without the works of mercy that express love for the neighbor, without the engagement with the social conditions that produce suffering — that person has misunderstood both holiness and grace. Grace transforms the individual; individual transformation flows into social transformation; social transformation is the arena in which individual grace is tested, deepened, and made real. The separation between the spiritual life and the social life is a failure of imagination, not a theological position. Wesley knew this. The Methodist class meeting, the Love Feast, the circuit rider's ministry to the poor, the abolitionist campaign, and the settlement house — all are expressions of the same sacred conviction: that love, when it is genuine, cannot be contained within the walls of a church or the boundaries of a soul. Grand Rising.